Rivervale Community Library: History

The Rivervale Community Library opened its doors on 12 March 1962 in a small brick building near the old railway station. Its first librarian was a schoolteacher named Anita Marlow, who donated 800 of her own books to start the collection.

By 1985 the collection had grown to more than 12,000 books, and the building was too small. The town council voted to build a new wing, which was finished in 1988 and named the Marlow Wing in honour of the founder.

In 2004 the library added its first public computers. There were six computers at the start, and they were booked in 30 minute slots. Today the library has 24 computers and free Wi-Fi throughout the building.

The library is run by a team of nine staff members and about forty volunteers. It is funded mostly by the town council, with additional help from local donations and the yearly book sale held every October.

Borrowing Rules

Every member of Rivervale Library can borrow up to 5 books at one time. The standard loan period is 14 days, and a book can be renewed twice if nobody else has reserved it.

Reference books, rare maps and newspapers from before 1950 cannot be taken home. They can only be read inside the Marlow Wing reading room.

If a book is returned late, the fine is 2 rupees per day for each book. The maximum fine for a single book is 100 rupees. Members who lose a book must pay its replacement price plus a handling fee of 50 rupees.

Children under 12 can borrow up to 8 picture books at a time, and they do not pay late fines. A library card is free for residents of Rivervale. Visitors from other towns pay a deposit of 200 rupees, which is returned when they close their account.

The Reading Garden

Behind the main building is the Reading Garden, which opened in the spring of 2011. It has 14 wooden benches, a small pond with six goldfish, and a row of apple trees planted by school children.

The garden is open from 8 in the morning until 6 in the evening, except on rainy days. Food is allowed in the garden, but pets are not. A quiet zone is marked near the pond, where phones must be kept silent.

Every Saturday at 10 in the morning, a volunteer named Dev Kulkarni reads stories aloud to children in the garden. The session lasts about 45 minutes and no booking is needed.

The garden is cleaned every Monday. Visitors are asked to keep the paths clear and to put the benches back in their places after use.

Library Cafe

The Library Cafe is on the ground floor, next to the main entrance. It is open from 9 in the morning until 5 in the evening, from Tuesday to Sunday, and it is closed on Mondays.

The most popular item is the masala tea, which costs 20 rupees. A filter coffee costs 30 rupees, and a plate of two vegetable samosas costs 40 rupees. On Fridays the cafe also serves a lemon cake that usually sells out by noon.

The cafe is run by a local women's cooperative with eight members. All the profit goes to buying new children's books for the library.

Laptops are allowed in the cafe, but the tables near the window are kept for people who are eating or drinking. Loud calls should be taken outside.

Contact and Events

The library is located at 27 Mill Road, Rivervale. The main phone number is 555 0142, and the email address is hello@rivervalelibrary.example.

Opening hours are 10 in the morning to 7 in the evening from Tuesday to Saturday, and 11 to 4 on Sundays. The library is closed on Mondays and on public holidays.

Three events are planned for the coming year. The Poetry Evening is on the first Friday of every month. The Book Sale takes place on 18 October, with all books priced between 10 and 50 rupees. The Coding Club for teenagers meets every Wednesday at 5 in the evening, and it is led by a volunteer named Sana Iqbal.

To volunteer, ask at the front desk for the form, or write to the email address above. New volunteers are asked to give at least 3 hours per month.